midnight, in the poem Lorde imagines going against accepted protocols and gestures to understand that the Berlin Wall is as porous. For example, Lorde writes the woman is “selling a season’s ticket to the Berlin Opera.” In a city with two opera houses—East Berlin’s Deutsche Staatsoper and West Berlin’s Deutsche Oper Berlin—Lorde opens up the East as a site of habitual (“season”) return.[60] Ultimately, she undermines the normalcy and logic of division in the dream space of the poem.

Further, Lorde’s use of the word “perhaps” throughout the work accentuates its liminal contexts and her own ambivalence about the city. Given her free-verse style, her poetic structure comes not from meter or rhyme per se but from the rhythm created through line breaks, stanzas, repetition, and spacing. The poem begins with the word “perhaps,” which then reappears six times, either by itself after a line break or with extra space separating it from other words on the line. Mimicking the actual zigzagged path of the Wall, the word acts as an unsteady refrain and snakes through the poem, offering the work a sense of structure. Thus Lorde undermines polemic division and singular political meaning, all while making sure the actions she explores in the poetic dream are both purposeful and conditional.

Contrasting the surreal realm of dream border crossings, her attention to extremes of tactility and texture is also important through both stanzas, as expressed through a litany of images suggesting what she deems “a tender forgiveness of contrasts,” including an interplay between the “hard” of “a granite bowl,” “a stone,” “metal,” and the soft of a “half-ripe banana,” “Mother Christopher’s warm bread,” “silken thighs,” and the “american flag.” These contrasts ground the dream and poem in the city’s material conditions—including military occupation and fortified borders—even as they summon ethereality and a forgiveness akin to letting go. Among these “contrasts,” Lorde’s rendering of “american” without an uppercase “A” offers an implicit troubling of her national belonging and conjures Alexis De Veaux’s formulation that Lorde selectively dropped the uppercase when traveling abroad.[61]

In the final lines, Lorde writes, “perhaps / A nightingale waits in the alley,” conjuring the nightingale. The bird, an important poetic symbol from antiquity to the Romantic period, embodies and negotiates a number of divisions explored in poetry, including expression and silence, masculinity and femininity, and the threshold between life and death.[62] For instance, John Keats’s “Ode to a Nightingale” looks to the bird, like a poem, as a way